The international climate was changing fast after Donald Trump was elected as President of the United States. His desire to make an early withdrawal of US forces from Afghanistan, coupled with a belief that Pakistan had taken the Americans for a financial ride over the years and allowed the Taliban inside Pakistan to target American forces, meant that America was now willing to press hard on Pakistan. Although the American priorities were Al-Qaida and ISIS, the Kashmir-centric terror outfits based in Pakistan also became additional pain-points that the Americans could press upon in order to secure Pakistan's cooperation in ensuring that US Special Envoy Zalmay Khalilzad was able to negotiate with the Taliban for an honourable American exit from Afghanistan.

Pakistan was, therefore, already facing the heat from America and its allies when the JeM conducted a terrorist attack against an Indian security convoy on the highway near Pulwama in Jammu and Kashmir, on 14 February 2019. Over forty Indian security personnel were murdered. It helped that in a video recording by the suicide bomber, he claimed to be a JeM member, and subsequently the JeM also claimed ownership of the attack. The Government of Pakistan's feeble denials did not find much international support. The gap between China and the rest became glaringly evident when India pressed for a Security Council statement condemning this heinous crime.

China's actions in delaying a statement until all references to Pakistan or Masood Azhar were expunged also exposed its behaviour to greater international scrutiny than it would have wished for. The Americans resubmitted an application on 27 February 2019 to list Masood Azhar in the 1267 Committee. This time the tactics that China had used earlier in their negotiations with India were no longer available to it. The Chinese had to overtly tilt to Pakistan to defend it after Pulwama and in the 1267 Committee the lone opposition by